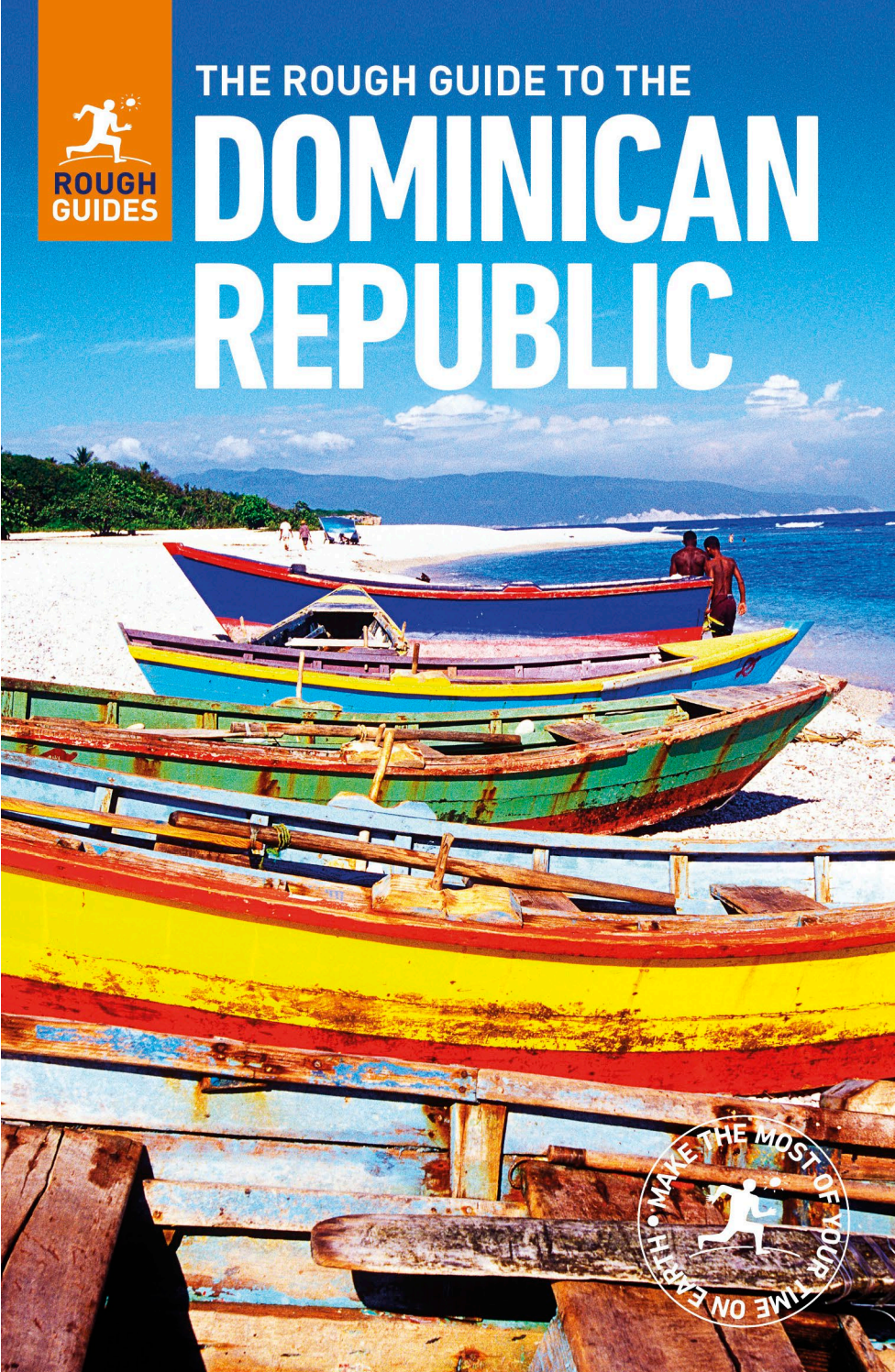
ROUGH GUIDES

THE ROUGH GUIDE TO THE DOMINICAN REPUBLIC



INSIDE THIS BOOK

INTRODUCTION What to see, what not to miss, itineraries and more

BASICS Pre-departure tips and practical information

THE GUIDE Comprehensive, in-depth guide to the Dominican Republic, with area highlights and full-colour maps throughout

CONTEXTS History, music, the environment, wildlife and baseball, plus recommended books and a useful language section

We've flagged up our favourite places – a perfectly sited hotel, an atmospheric café, a special restaurant – throughout the guide with the ★ symbol

Dominican Republic chapters



1 Santo Domingo
2 The southeast
3 The Samaná Peninsula and Parque Nacional Los Haitises
4 The Silver Coast
5 The Cibao
6 The southwest

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THE ROUGH GUIDE TO THE DOMINICAN REPUBLIC

This seventh edition updated by
Matt Norman and Charles Young

ROUGH GUIDES


BAHIA
tropical

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OPPOSITE BEACH CLEANING AT BOCA CHICA **PREVIOUS PAGE** FLAMINGOS AT LAGUNA OVIEDO



Introduction to the Dominican Republic

The mystery, but also part of the appeal, of the Dominican Republic is that this lush, vibrant and geographically diverse country is not more popular with independent travellers. As the Caribbean's top holiday destination, it attracts millions of package tourists to its stunning white-sand, palm-fringed beaches, but it's so full of lesser-known coastal, highland and even desert attractions that it's also ideal for getting off the beaten track. After all, flight prices to the DR, as it's commonly known, are among the lowest in the region and getting around this relatively small but surprisingly mountainous country by public transport is not only cheap and easy, once you get the hang of it, but it can be fun as well. Packing yourself into a crowded minibus full of locals may not be everyone's idea of a good time but you won't find a quicker way of getting a taste of the close-knit, gregarious Dominican sense of community. Even the remotest corners of the DR are connected by bus, while finding affordable accommodation is no problem either, with increasing numbers of rental rooms, hostels and gorgeous guesthouses.

As well as the hundreds of pristine beaches along the DR's 1500km coastline, you can count on 166km of coral reefs and 325 square kilometres of mangroves. Besides rainforest there are vast tracts of pine forest, much of which can be found in the country's many **national parks** and **nature reserves**. Occupying gentler plots of land are the manicured greens of over 25 designer golf courses, complementing the countless spots for other **outdoor pursuits**, including mountain rapids for whitewater rafting, extensive limestone cave systems for spelunking, dirt tracks on the slopes of

ABOVE CAYO LEVANTADO, SAMANÁ **OPPOSITE** FRUIT STALL, NEAR PUNTA CANA

sierras for mountain biking, one of the world's best kitesurfing spots in Cabarete, and the largest breeding ground for the North Atlantic humpback whale population in the Samaná Bay, providing the scene for some of the most unforgettable nautical excursions anywhere.

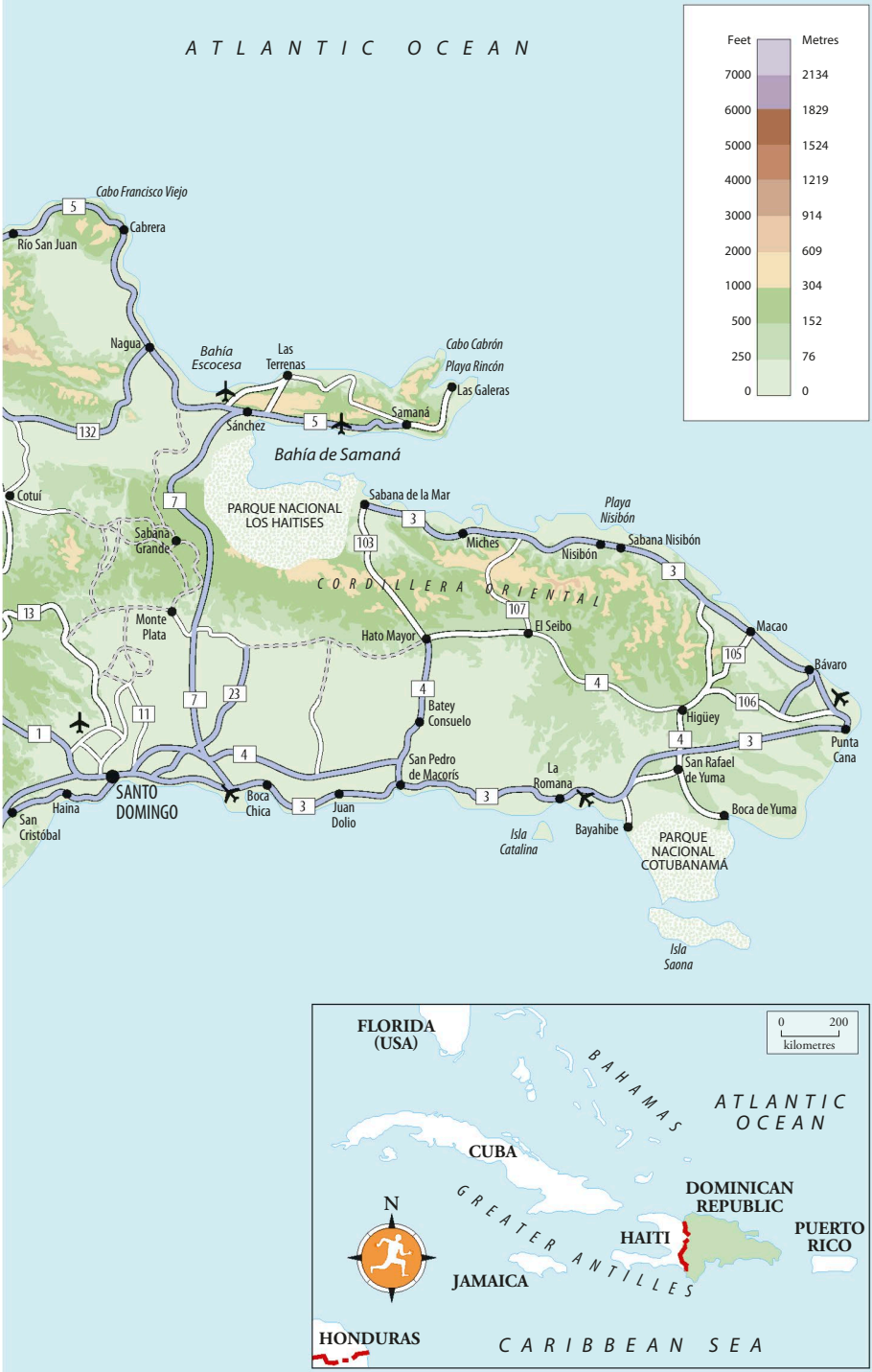
Next, throw rich and theatrical Dominican **culture** into the mix. Locals let themselves go to the sophisticated and intoxicating rhythms of merengue and bachata – musical styles native to the DR – while **religion** remains an overt and integral part of life, with crucifixes hanging around millions of necks, Jesus praised on countless bus and car stickers and – adding an enthralling Caribbean twist – Catholic symbolism mixed with African religious custom. The exhibitionist streak accompanying all this can be experienced first-hand at a vibrant **fiesta patronal**. Held in every town across the country, these celebrations in the name of a patron saint usually involve music-driven, round-the-clock processions and street parties that can last several days.

Even outside of festival times most towns in the DR, whether large or small, are boisterous places with a lively **street life**, an apparently lawless traffic system, especially in Santo Domingo, and always a buzzing sense of commerce. While vast supermarkets and swish shopping malls point to the strong North American influence on society, a huge number of independent, family-run businesses provide every town centre with a distinctly Dominican flavour, packed as they are with colourful shop fronts, grocery stores crammed ceiling-high with cans, tins and jars, and where, on weekend nights,



DOMINICAN REPUBLIC




ATLANTIC OCEAN
Feet
Metres
7000
2134
6000
1829
5000
1524
4000
1219
3000
914
2000
609
1000
304
500
152
250
76
0
0
Cabo Francisco Viejo
Cabrera
Río San Juan
Nagua
Bahía Escocesa
Las Terrenas
Cabo Cabrón
Playa Rincón
Las Galeras
Samaná
Sánchez
Bahía de Samaná
Cotuí
PARQUE NACIONAL LOS HAITISES
Sabana de la Mar
Playa Nisibón
Sabana Grande
Miches
Nisibón
Sabana Nisibón
CORDILLERA ORIENTAL
Monte Plata
Hato Mayor
El Seibo
Macao
Bávaro
Batey
Consuelo
Higüey
Punta Cana
San Rafael de Yuma
San Pedro de Macorís
La Romana
Boca de Yuma
SANTO DOMINGO
Haina
San Cristóbal
Boca Chica
Juan Dolio
Isla Catalina
Bayahibe
PARQUE NACIONAL COTUBANAMÁ
Isla Saona
FLORIDA (USA)
BAHAMAS
ATLANTIC OCEAN
0
200
kilometres
CUBA
DOMINICAN REPUBLIC
N
GREATER ANTILLES
HAITI
PUERTO RICO
JAMAICA
HONDURAS
CARIBBEAN SEA

FACT FILE

- Sharing its western border with Haiti, the Dominican Republic is bound to the south by the Caribbean Sea and to the north and east by the Atlantic Ocean. It is the **second-largest country** in the Caribbean and covers 48,442 square kilometres.
- The **highest and lowest points** in the Caribbean – Pico Duarte (3087m) and Lago Enriquillo (-46m) respectively – are both in the Dominican Republic.
- Ethnically, the **population** is predominantly of mixed African and European ancestry, as the indigenous Taíno who inhabited the Dominican Republic before Columbus's arrival were almost entirely wiped out by Spanish invasion and European diseases. The population is currently 72 percent mixed race, 16 percent white, 11 percent black and 1 percent made up of other ethnic groups.
- The capital city, **Santo Domingo**, is the oldest European-founded city in the New World, dating from 1496. The scenes in *The Godfather Part II* set in Havana were actually filmed in Santo Domingo.
- The Dominican Republic is the largest exporter of **cigars** in the world.
- The country was ruled by the dictator **General Rafael Leonidas Trujillo Molina** from 1930 until his assassination in 1961. During his brutal reign he renamed the capital city Ciudad Trujillo and the country's highest mountain Pico Trujillo.

the staff are as likely to be dancing with customers as they are to be serving them. Around a third of the population live in **rural areas**, which, though unsurprisingly more subdued than the towns and cities, often throw up a quirky mix of modern and traditional, with block-rocking sound systems mounted in SUVs engulfing entire villages in reggaeton, and mobile-phone shops selling the latest iPhones to tobacco farmers.

Many visitors are also struck by the **friendliness** and helpfulness of Dominicans – they won't stop at giving you a few directions, they'll walk you there; and just when you think they're about to ask for something in return, they shake your hand and wish you luck.

Where to go

Many visitors head directly for beachfront resorts, and there's much at these holiday retreats to enjoy. The southeastern part of the country has the largest all-inclusive resort zone, **Punta Cana** and **Bávaro**, which has pristine coastline stretching for kilometres on end and is increasingly accessible to backpackers, with several hostels in among the giant sprawling hotels. Up on the north coast, and also dedicated to mass tourism, is the mega-complex **Playa Dorada**, whose appeal is enhanced by its proximity to the historic city of **Puerto Plata** – with its wealth of Victorian architecture – and to wind- and kitesurfing capital **Cabarete**.

Of course, you needn't base yourself in a resort in order to visit the DR's most popular sights, and there are plenty of opportunities for independent travellers to range further afield. A quest for immaculate beaches may take you to the most remote corners of the southwest, where your efforts will be rewarded with the breathtaking sands of the **Jaragua Peninsula**. This little-visited corner of the country is also home to impressive **Lago Enriquillo**, a huge saltwater lake full of crocodiles and a truly fabulous array of tropical birds. There are some beautiful, and far more accessible, beaches scattered about the **Samaná Peninsula**, poking out at the country's extreme northeast. Its provincial

CROWD-FREE BEACHES

With hundreds of kilometres of **beach** spread around every part of the meandering coastline, you needn't go far to find a sandy shore. The likes of **Punta Cana** and **Playa Dorada** are world-famous, but there are innumerable lesser-known gems worth seeking out. In the north, along the Silver Coast west of Puerto Plata, the poor state of the roads ensures that relatively few visitors make it as far as **Laguna Estero Hondo**, a great spot for snorkelling and one where you might – just might – spot a manatee in the protected waters. At the other end of the north coast, at the extreme east of the Samaná Peninsula, make for: secluded **Playa Frontón**, hiding behind sheltering cliffs; **Playa Madama** (pictured below), a tiny, serene beach, only reachable by boat, horseback or hiking; and increasingly popular **Playa Rincón**, a spectacular curve of sand that is still quite empty some days. Also on the peninsula is **Playa Bonita** near Las Terrenas, which is easy to get to but surprisingly calm and peaceful, particularly if you walk around its western point. In the southeast, just up the coast from the busiest beach in the country, are **Playa Nisibón** and **Playa Limón**, whose mountain backdrop provides both the gorgeous setting and the barrier to getting there easily. Remotest and least accessible of the lot is the beach at **Bahía de las Águilas** in the distant southwest, where stunningly beautiful white powdery sand is lapped by azure water.



capital, the small city of Samaná, serves as a base for checking out the humpback whales that migrate to the Bahía de Samaná each winter, while **Las Terrenas** is the peninsula's liveliest town. Its long, sandy seafront is lined with expat-owned hotels, tour operators and popular restaurants and bars; secluded paradise isn't far away, either, at the beaches of playas **Bonita** and **Rincón**.

On the central southern coast the capital, **Santo Domingo**, is among the most cosmopolitan cities in the Caribbean, with a collection of excellent museums and galleries, three huge city parks, an expanding metro system and a vibrant social scene. The historic forts, churches and the elegant homes of the **Zona Colonial** form its compact centre, with the modern, high-rise-heavy financial and shopping districts stretching out beyond it, home to impressive upscale restaurants and trendy nightclubs.

If you're seeking a bit more adventure and outdoor life, head for the **Cordillera Central**, the island's largest and the Caribbean's highest mountain range, providing the stunning

BASEBALL STADIUM CULTURE

Baseball (see p.37) is an integral part of Dominican culture and it's inside the stadiums of the six Winter League teams that the **national passion** for the sport and the idiosyncrasies of the game here are at their most addictive. With capacities ranging between 8000 and 18,000, Dominican ball parks are relatively small, certainly compared to MLB stadiums, lending them an appealing intimacy and, when they are full, an intensity that can be electrifying. Games are at their most animated and crowded when the **Aguilas Cibaeñas** of Santiago (see box, p.211) match up against Santo Domingo's **Tigres del Licey** (see box, p.82), and more still if it's a Sunday game, especially during the playoffs. The **atmosphere** in general is lively and festive: merengue blasts over the public address system and music is played live by bands in the stands. Adding to the noise are whistles, horns, vuvuzelas and drums making some games cacophonous. But it's always imbued with a sense of fun, and fans are never less than expressive when their team delivers so much as a base hit, jumping up on their seats, dancing and waving flags. Cheerleaders, dancers and mascots perform on the pitch during breaks in play and, throughout games, old men in the back of the bleachers are making and taking bets on every movement going on in the field.



OPPOSITE A GUITAR LESSON OUTSIDE CONVENTO DE LOS DOMINICOS, SANTO DOMINGO; MERCADO MODELO, SANTO DOMINGO





setting for multiday treks through the wilderness to the summit of the tallest peak, **Pico Duarte**. The most popular starting point for these treks is **Jarabacoa**, a resort town just two hours by bus from Santo Domingo, which is blessed with a cluster of four waterfalls in its immediate vicinity and features all manner of mountain sports. Another great base for hiking here is breathtakingly beautiful **Constanza**, a farmed valley with a small town at its heart, all perfectly packaged by the surrounding mountains.

When to go

There are two distinct tourist **high seasons** in the Dominican Republic: the **summer months** of July and August, when travellers from the northern hemisphere fill the resorts and all but the most out-of-the-way beaches; and the **winter season** between December and the start of April, when the Dominican climate is at its optimum, having cooled down a little from the summer. You'll therefore save a bit of money – and have an easier time booking a hotel room on the spot – if you arrive during the **spring** or the **autumn**, which is just fine, as the temperature doesn't really vary all that much from season to season, with the annual average around 25°C. Bear in mind that May to mid-November constitutes the DR's **rainy season**, though not all heavy rains are concentrated into these months – you can often get two weeks of unbroken sunshine in the summer and torrential downpours in January.

The **humidity** is relatively low during the winter months and it tends to cool down in the evenings much more than in the summer months. Furthermore, in the **mountainous interior** of the country, particularly in the Cordillera Central, it is always significantly cooler, and on the highest mountain peaks the temperatures have been known to drop below zero. Be aware also that the Dominican Republic is in the centre of the Caribbean hurricane belt, and gets hit with a major storm every decade or so. The **hurricane season** runs roughly from June to November with the stormiest months usually August and September.

AVERAGE MONTHLY TEMPERATURES AND RAINFALL

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
PUERTO PLATA												
Temp (°F)	73	73	75	75	79	81	81	81	81	81	79	75
Temp (°C)	23	23	24	24	26	27	27	27	27	27	26	24
Rainfall (mm)	193	154	121	157	128	62	71	82	91	137	293	280
CONSTANZA												
Temp (°F)	61	63	63	64	66	68	68	68	68	66	64	63
Temp (°C)	16	17	17	18	19	20	20	20	20	19	18	17
Rainfall (mm)	200	83	129	167	130	74	70	69	88	131	194	179
PUNTA CANA												
Temp (°F)	79	79	79	79	81	81	82	82	82	81	79	79
Temp (°C)	26	26	26	26	27	27	28	28	28	27	26	26
Rainfall (mm)	58	44	46	58	113	113	84	93	78	120	130	87

Author picks

The waters and forests of the Samaná Peninsula Opportunities to go whale watching, horseback riding, hiking to waterfalls, boating around mangroves and scuba diving abound on this gorgeous peninsula and can be easily arranged from any of the three main visitor hubs: Las Terrenas (p.140), Las Galeras (p.135) and Samaná (p.124).

Party time in the Zona Colonial Santo Domingo's centuries-old streets and plazas host some fantastic free concerts which always double up as street parties. Join the crowds at the atmospheric ruins of the first monastery in the Americas for Grupo Bonye (p.79) and on the steps of El Conde for Noches de Jazz (p.79).

Guaguas and conchos Whether sitting in the back of a pick-up truck rolling through the Cordillera Central or squeezed into a minibus on a highway, guaguas and *conchos* (p.24) are central to the DR experience – they're cheap, sociable and will get you almost anywhere.

Colonial interiors in Santo Domingo Enjoy the beautiful architecture of some of the country's most captivating buildings in Santo Domingo's Zona Colonial – by sleeping, eating or drinking in them. Dine in style at *Meson D' Bari* and *La Bricíola* (pp.76–77); sleep between the arches at *Casa Sánchez*, *Villa Colonial* or *El Beaterio* (pp.74–75); and sink a beer in the *Casa de Teatro* (p.80) before catching a performance.

Parque Duarte One of the capital's most sociable and feel-good spots, well-kept Parque Duarte (p.78) simply buzzes at weekends – with its easy co-existence of gay and straight revellers, it goes some way to destroying the idea that the Caribbean is rabidly homophobic, too. Dominican street life at its best.

Salcedo in the Cibao This Dominican Bedford Falls is the best of small-town DR in its simplicity and friendliness – there are colourful murals on many of the buildings, merengue echoes through the streets and it's one of the safest urban centres in the country (p.232).

Our author recommendations don't end here. We've flagged up our favourite places – a perfectly sited hotel, an atmospheric café, a special restaurant – throughout the guide, highlighted with the ★ symbol.







FROM TOP LOCAL MINIBUS; HORSERIDING ON PLAYA RINCÓN; SALCEDO

17

things not to miss

It's not possible to see everything the Dominican Republic has to offer in one trip – and we don't suggest you try. What follows is a selective and subjective taste of the country's highlights: gorgeous beaches, colonial relics, outdoor activities and plenty of dancing. All highlights are colour-coded by chapter and have a page reference to take you straight into the guide, where you can find out more.









1 PLAYA FRONTÓN
Page 140
Shielded from the rest of the world by encapsulating cliffs, this fabulous beach is hard to get to and hard to forget.

2 SANTO DOMINGO'S ZONA COLONIAL
Page 50
The capital's compact historic district is a treasure-trove of colonial architecture and picturesque squares, with the best selection of restaurants in the city.

3 CABARETE
Page 176
This lively beach town boasts the best windsurfing and kiteboarding in the Caribbean.

4 CONSTANZA
Page 228
A circular Shangri-La valley set deep in the heart of the Caribbean's tallest mountains.



5



6



7



8





5 BAHÍA DE LAS ÁGUILAS
Page 255
Completely clear of hotels and restaurants, this wonderful beach is as remote as they get in the DR.

6 LAGO ENRIQUILLO
Page 258
A saltwater lake the size of Manhattan, populated by crocodiles, rhinoceros iguanas and tens of thousands of tropical birds.

7 WHITEWATER RAFTING
Page 222
An adrenaline-fuelled adventure and a great way to see the country's more remote mountain scenery.

8 LAGUNA OVIEDO
Page 254
This scenic, little-visited lake is often white with salt, setting off the pink flamingos that frequent it to a T.

9 BASEBALL
Page 37
See some of the best young players in the world, and even some of the veteran Dominican stars of MLB, in the national Winter League.

10 WHALE WATCHING
Page 131
One of the world's great natural spectacles takes place every winter in Samaná Bay when thousands of humpback whales arrive to breed, give birth and fill the memory cards of the watching tourists' cameras.

11 LA VEGA CARNIVAL
Page 220
Each February, La Vega transforms itself with the biggest, wildest party in this Carnival-crazed nation.





12 LIVE MUSIC AND DANCE AT RUINAS DE SAN FRANCISCO

Page 79

Join the concert-goers and swirling dancers on Sunday evenings in Santo Domingo and get down to the merengue, salsa and son of a top-notch sixteen-piece band.

13 EL LIMÓN WATERFALL

Page 148

Hidden deep within the Samaná mountains, but accessible on horseback, this pristine 150m waterfall is one of the loveliest spots on the island.

14 MOUNTAIN BIKING IN THE CORDILLERA SEPTENTRIONAL

Page 179

Choose from all-day downhill rides to multiday treks for experts, with stunning mountain scenery as your backdrop.

15 PICO DUARTE

Page 225

Climb to the rooftop of the Caribbean along five strenuous trails of varying lengths – sublime views guaranteed.

16 AMBER

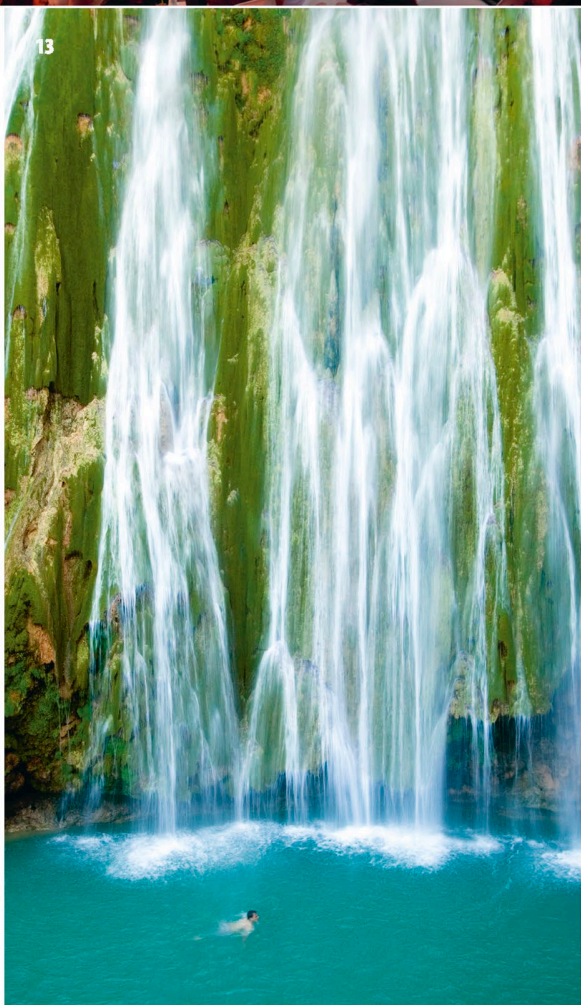
Page 42

Unbeatable as an authentic, locally produced souvenir, this semiprecious stone is stunning when set in jewellery.

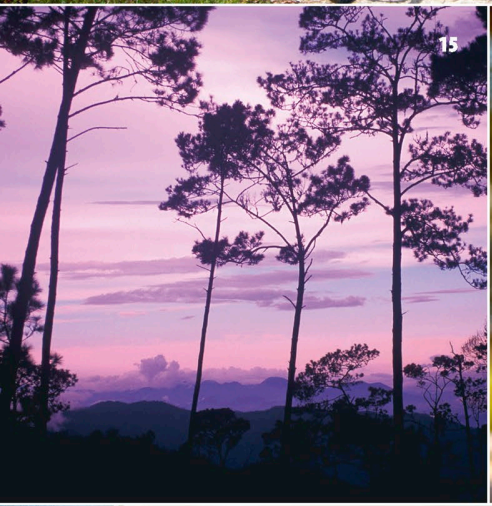
17 MUSEO DE ARTE MODERNO, SANTO DOMINGO

Page 64

This impressive and accessible museum, one of four in Santo Domingo's Plaza de la Cultura, houses the most complete collection of contemporary Dominican visual art in the country.

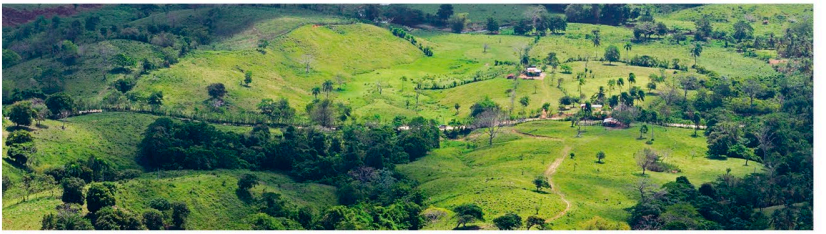



14


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Itineraries

Size-wise, the DR isn't daunting – but it does an awful lot with the available space. Our Grand Tour is a jam-packed, two-week route around the headline acts, while the other two itineraries can be done in a shorter space of time – or at a more leisurely pace – with no need to stay the night at every stop.

THE GRAND TOUR

Allow two weeks for this whistle-stop tour, taking in distinctly wild, remote-feeling landscapes and the largest city in the Caribbean.

❶ **Punta Cana and Bávaro** Start at the country's largest resort zone, which offers a good selection of inexpensive, independent hotels nestled amid the all-inclusives. **See p.110**

❷ **Santo Domingo** Give yourself at least three days to see the capital, prioritizing the Zona Colonial, but taking in at least one of the museums, restaurants or parks beyond the old city. **See p.46**

❸ **Samaná Peninsula** The Samaná Peninsula is mesmerizingly picturesque and perfect for independent tourists, with loads of great, affordable places to stay and unforgettable whale watching. **See p.122**

❹ **Cabarete** One of the premier spots in the country for watersports, Cabarete can lay claim to near-perfect kiteboarding conditions. **See p.176**

❺ **Santiago** The DR's second city has plenty going on and combines a lively going-out scene with a laidback charm. **See p.207**

❻ **Cordillera Central** Pick your base for hiking in the "Dominican Alps" – Jarabacoa, the town best set up for tourism; San José de las Matas, a sleepy mountain village with breathtaking views of the mountains; or Constanza, a lush, scenic valley. **See p.218**

❼ **Lago Enriquillo** Enormous Lago Enriquillo is the headline attraction in the remote southwest, home to a large population of American crocodiles and tropical birds. **See p.258**

CITIES, BEACHES AND MOUNTAINS

Travel from the south to the north coast via the Cordillera Central, the largest mountain range in the Caribbean, taking in the DR's two main cities.

❶ **Santo Domingo** If short on time in the capital, restrict yourself to the Zona Colonial, with its historic sights, excellent restaurants and nightlife. **See p.46**

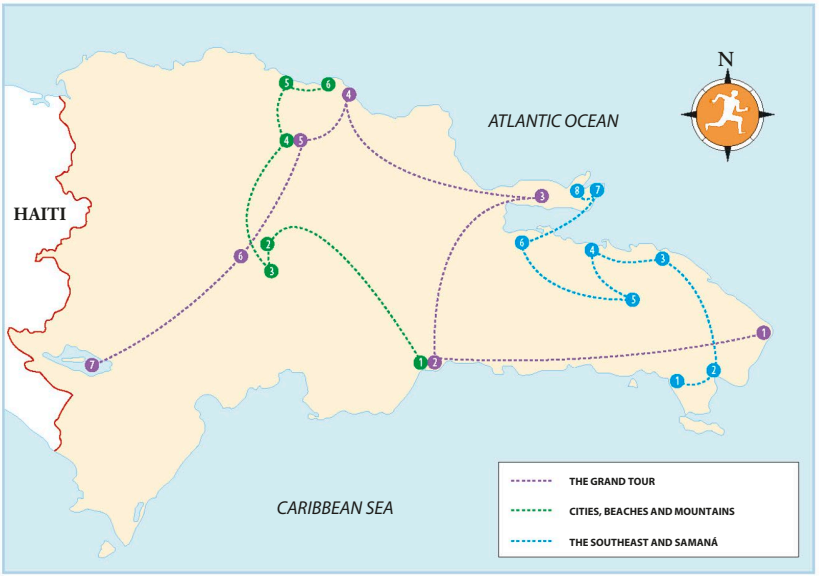
❷ **Jarabacoa** Right in the thick of the Cordillera Central, Jarabacoa gives easy access to whitewater rafting, hiking trails and four memorable waterfalls. **See p.221**

❸ **Constanza** At 1300m above sea level, breathtakingly beautiful Constanza is the highest populated mountain valley in the country and another great base for hiking. **See p.228**

❹ **Santiago** The country's second city offers an entirely different experience to the capital – set against a mountainous backdrop and with its roots in agriculture, it's less cosmopolitan and less urban but rich in cultural heritage. **See p.207**

❺ **Puerto Plata and Playa Dorada** Playa Dorada has passed the mantle of premier

ABOVE CORDILLERA ORIENTAL, THE SOUTHEAST



DR beach resort to Punta Cana, but with marvellous beaches and a cultural, history-rich neighbour in Puerto Plata, it still has the edge over its southern rival. **See p.155**

❻ **Sosúa** A pleasant little place with a set of inviting beaches, more tranquil than Puerto Plata to the west and Cabarete to the east, this charming resort town is a fine place to unwind. From here there are regular buses back to Santo Domingo, four hours away. **See p.169**

THE SOUTHEAST AND SAMANÁ

It's at the heart of the package tourism industry, but the southeast has gorgeous, little-visited beaches, virtually tourist-free towns and a ferry link to the Samaná Peninsula.

❶ **Bayahibe** A fraction of the size but proportionally less commercial and more pleasantly subdued than Punta Cana, this is where all the seafaring day-trippers come for their boat rides and diving – save yourself a bus ride and stay a night or two here instead. **See p.100**

❷ **Boca de Yuma** Just 40km down the coast from Punta Cana but not connected directly by public transport, Boca de Yuma may only have a pin-prick of a beach in comparison – but its end-of-the-road appeal makes up for it. **See p.108**

❸ **Playas Limón and Nisibón** These long stretches of pristine beach at the rugged edges of the Cordillera Oriental are two of the southeast's hidden highlights. **See p.119**

❹ **Miches** A short way along the brand-new road from Playa Limon is the unassuming town of Miches, with its own decent beach and a beautifully located hotel and restaurant overlooking the town from a hill. **See p.117**

❺ **El Seibo** This pleasant little town is as much about the journey as the destination, the twisting road from Miches passing through the most scenic part of the unspoilt Cordillera Oriental. **See p.118**

❻ **Parque Nacional Los Haitises** Few travellers actually spend the night at this unmissable national park, but they're missing out on one of the most memorable hotels in the country: *Paraíso de Caño Hondo*. **See p.133**

❼ **Las Galeras** Catch the small ferry boat from Sabana de la Mar and head straight from Samaná to Las Galeras, a sleepy place full of fantastic independent hotels. **See p.135**

❽ **Playas Rincón and Frontón** While in Las Galeras make at least one boat trip out to one of these outlying beaches – Playa Rincón with its 2km-curve of sand or isolated Playa Frontón, protected by black cliffs. **See pp.139–140**



BROWSING THE SHOPS AT PLAYA SOSÚA

Basics

23 Getting there
24 Getting around
28 Accommodation
30 Food and drink
32 Festivals
33 Sports and outdoor activities
37 Travel essentials

Getting there

The Dominican Republic is well connected to the outside world and you'll find a plethora of flight options from North America and Europe. The primary points of entry are Santo Domingo, Puerto Plata and Punta Cana, with additional international airports at Santiago, Samaná and La Romana.

The huge all-inclusive tourism industry built up along Dominican shores means that there are plenty of package deals for airfare, hotel and food, with astounding rates available to those willing to shop around. But even if you don't want to go all-inclusive, the air charters regularly offer extra seats to independent travellers for a surprisingly low price. Those headed here from Australia, New Zealand and South Africa will find fewer bargains, but with a bit of stamina you can make your way to the DR via the major airlines, though you won't be able to avoid a transfer at some point along the way.

Flights from the UK and Ireland

British Airways (Ⓦ britishairways.com) currently runs daily **direct flights** from London Gatwick to Punta Cana; its cheapest fares are between £500 and £650. The only other airlines flying direct from the UK to the Dominican Republic are Thomson Airways (Ⓦ thomson.co.uk) and Thomas Cook Airlines (Ⓦ thomascookairlines.com), both operating a mixture of scheduled and charter services; their timetabled flights to Punta Cana depart twice a week from London Gatwick and Manchester respectively. Thomas Cook Airlines tends to offer some of the cheapest options on the market, with fares occasionally lower than £400.

You can sometimes save money by flying **indirect**, for which there are countless choices. There are daily American Airlines (Ⓦ americanairlines.co.uk) flights from London to Punta Cana, Santo Domingo, Santiago and Puerto Plata via various US airports (most often Miami). You can also connect to Dominican airports via cities all over Europe: Iberia (Ⓦ iberia.com) and Air Europa (Ⓦ aireuropa.com) fly direct from Madrid, the latter offering consistently cheap fares but below-average in-flight amenities; Air France (Ⓦ airfrance.co.uk) flies direct from Paris and Air Berlin (Ⓦ airberlin.com) direct from Berlin.

There are no direct flights to the Dominican Republic from **Ireland**. American Airlines, United Airlines (Ⓦ united.com) and Delta (Ⓦ delta.com) fly from Ireland with connections in various US cities to the major Dominican airports while British Airways, Air France and Iberia connect via cities in Europe and, through their partner airlines, in the US.

Flights from the US and Canada

There are **direct flights** to the Dominican Republic from numerous US cities, though travelling from the west coast will require a connection. Between them, American Airlines (Ⓦ aa.com), United Airlines (Ⓦ united.com), Delta (Ⓦ delta.com) and budget airline JetBlue (Ⓦ jetblue.com) connect Miami and New York directly to all the Dominican international airports with the cheapest and most frequent flights. Philadelphia, Atlanta and Boston all connect directly to Punta Cana and Santo Domingo, while there are direct flights from at least another seven US cities, including Chicago, Detroit, Charlotte, Miami, Washington DC and Orlando, to one Dominican airport or another. **Fares** on JetBlue, which has one of the most comprehensive rosters of flights, start at around US$350.

You can fly direct from a dozen **Canadian** cities to Punta Cana and from Toronto and Montréal to most Dominican airports, though you'll be lucky to get a direct flight for less than CAN$450. Air Transat (Ⓦ airtransat.com) has the most services, linking Toronto with Puerto Plata and Punta Cana year-round and Samaná, Santo Domingo and La Romana in high season, and Montréal with Puerto Plata, Punta Cana and Samaná year-round plus La Romana in high season. Air Canada (Ⓦ aircanada.com), WestJet (Ⓦ westjet.com) and Sunwing Airlines (Ⓦ sunwing.ca) all fly direct to Punta Cana from either Montréal or Toronto, though none flies direct to Santo Domingo.

A BETTER KIND OF TRAVEL

At Rough Guides we are passionately committed to travel. We believe it helps us understand the world we live in and the people we share it with – and of course tourism is vital to many developing economies. But the scale of modern tourism has also damaged some places irreparably, and climate change is accelerated by most forms of transport, especially flying. All Rough Guides' flights are carbon-offset, and every year we donate money to a variety of environmental charities.

Flights from Australia, New Zealand and South Africa

The Caribbean is not a bargain destination from **Australia** or **New Zealand**. Because there are **no direct flights** to the Dominican Republic, you'll need to travel first to the US or Europe. It's a day-long slog whichever way you go, but most convenient **from Australia** is a direct flight from Sydney to New York City with Qantas (Ⓦ qantas.com), followed by an onward connection to the DR with one of the North American airlines listed below. From **New Zealand** you can take a direct flight from Auckland to New York with a stop in Los Angeles and get an onward connection from there. The cheapest fares start at around Aus$2000/NZ$2500.

Travellers from **South Africa** can get to Santo Domingo on Iberia airlines (Ⓦ ibera.com), though stops at Madrid and/or London are involved, and to Puerto Plata and Punta Cana with British Airways, stopping in London and/or Miami. Expect to pay upwards of ZAR15,000.

AGENTS AND OPERATORS

Apple Vacations US Ⓦ applevacations.com. Online package-holiday company with a long history in the Dominican market. Organizes all-inclusive trips from most of the US to Puerto Plata, Punta Cana, Samaná, Santiago and La Romana.

Aquatic Adventures US Ⓣ 954 382 0024, Ⓦ aquaticadventures.com. Florida-based outfit specializing exclusively in week-long, all-inclusive whale-watching cruises in the Silver Banks Sanctuary from US$4095, departing from Puerto Plata. The price doesn't include airfare.

Caribbean Warehouse UK Ⓣ 0844 4999 330, Ⓦ caribbeanwarehouse.co.uk. Well-respected specialist in Caribbean holidays run by the award-winning UK independent Blue Bay Travel company.

CheapCaribbean.com US Ⓣ 800 915 2322, Ⓦ cheapcaribbean.com. All-inclusive package-holiday specialist; it often has excellent-value late deals online.

STA Travel UK Ⓣ 0333 321 0099; Australia Ⓣ 134782; New Zealand Ⓣ 0800 474 400; SA Ⓣ 0861 781 781; Ⓦ statravel.com. Worldwide specialists in independent travel. Good discounts for students and under-26s.

Sunquest Canada Ⓣ 877 485 6060, Ⓦ sunquestvacations.ca. All-inclusive holidays to Punta Cana, Puerto Plata, Sosúa, Cabarete, Samaná and La Romana from Toronto and Ottawa, with connections from all major Canadian cities.

Trailfinders UK Ⓣ 0845 058 5858; Republic of Ireland Ⓣ 01 677 7888; Australia Ⓣ 1300 780 212; Ⓦ trailfinders.com. One of the best informed, most trusted and most efficient agents for independent travellers.

Getting around

Buses in all their shapes and sizes, known as guaguas (pronounced wah-wahs), are everywhere in the Dominican Republic. There is barely a village in the whole country that is not served by at least one guagua service, allowing visitors to avoid tackling the roads in rental cars – a good thing given recent World Health Organization statistics showing the country to be the worst in the Americas for road fatalities. If you do decide to drive yourself around, it's vital to exercise every precaution outlined below, with the pre-eminent advice being to avoid travelling by road at night.

Within towns guaguas are joined by *conchos*, shared taxis, often running fixed routes, and *motoconchos*, motorbike taxis. There's also usually a reliable 24-hour formal **taxi service** that you can call for pick-ups, though they typically cost a bit more, or, in some areas, online-only options which offer inexpensive fares.

By bus/guagua

The first thing to understand when getting your head around public transport in the DR is that while for Dominicans the terms **autobus** and **guagua** are in theory interchangeable, the colloquial term for any kind of bus, whether large air-conditioned coaches or battered minibuses, is almost exclusively the latter. Many foreign visitors mistakenly assume that it is only the ubiquitous minibuses and smaller vehicles that are considered guaguas but this is not the case. Autobus is often preferred in more formal contexts, such as signs for toll-road lanes or transport company websites, but is rarely heard in the popular vernacular.

Companies and syndicates

Caribe Tours (Ⓣ 802 221 4422, Ⓦ caribetours.com.do), the closest thing the DR has to a national bus network, provides an excellent, inexpensive service over much of the country, with the glaring exception of the whole of the southeast. There's plenty of room for luggage on its vehicles and, uniquely, it allows you to reserve online, provided you confirm two hours before departure. It has connections to the Cibao, the Samaná Peninsula, the Barahona region, the entire Silver Coast and even Port-au-Prince, Haiti. Only a few other bus companies, all of them very reliable and professional, have websites, notably **Metro** (Ⓣ 809 227 0101, Ⓦ metroserviciosturisticos.com), which connects the capital, Santiago, Puerto Plata and Sosúa; **APTPRA** (Ⓣ 809 686 0637, Ⓦ aptpra.com.do), covering the larger cities and resorts in the southeast; and the **Expreso Bávaro** service

CROSSING THE HAITIAN BORDER

There are **four legal border crossings**: the two busiest and best organized are at **Dajabón–Ouanaminthe** in the north and **Jimaní–Malpasse**, on the road between Santo Domingo and Port-au-Prince; more haphazard are the **Comendador–Belladere** border point midway between the north and south coasts and the remote **Pedernales–Anse-à-Pitre** crossing on the south coast. All are open daily from 8am to 6pm (Dominican time) – you can't cross outside these times and it's best to steer clear of the border areas and roads after dark for safety reasons.

The easiest way to cross is by bus/guagua. **Capital Coach Line** (T 809 530 8266, W capitalcoachline.com) offers a very efficient service with comfortable buses that run twice daily from Santo Domingo to Port-au-Prince (US$40/RD$1880), at 8am (to Tabarre) and 10am (to Petionville); high demand means it's sensible to book tickets in advance, which you can do online or at its terminal at Av. 27 de Febrero 455 in the El Millón district, 7km west of the Zona Colonial. **Caribe Tours** (see opposite) also offers a service to Port-au-Prince from Santo Domingo (US$39/RD$1820), departing daily at 9am and 11am, and a service from Santiago to Cap-Haitien (US$24/RD$1135), Haiti's second city, in the north, departing at 11.30am.

No one is allowed to bring a **rental car** across the Haitian–Dominican border, so unless you own a car in the DR, you won't be able to drive into Haiti or vice versa. On either side of the border you should have no problem picking up a guagua or *taptap* (the Haitian equivalent) or a *motoconcho*. However you travel, be prepared to have your baggage inspected when crossing the border, especially when returning from Haiti.

There's a US$30 **departure tax** (usually included in flight tickets) which you'll pay either when you buy a bus ticket or at the border itself, often along with an unregistered payment of US$5 to the Haitian officials. Returning from Haiti, you will probably have to pay another US$30 departure tax (though Dominican officials advise that the tax on the DR side allows you to re-enter at the same point for no additional payment), plus a further US$10 for a new Dominican tourist card.

(T 809 682 9670, W expresobavaro.com) which links Santo Domingo with Punta Cana and Bávaro.

There are hundreds of other guagua companies, many of them well run, serving just one region or often just one single route. Most of them are run by *sindicatos* or *asociaciones* and are known by their acronyms, such as SITRAHIMI (Sindicato de Transporte Interurbano Higuey-Miches). All guagua services are cheap but the size and comfort of vehicles varies considerably, ranging from double-decker coaches with on-board movies to battered minibuses with no luggage hold and on which you should be prepared for some discomfort. Pick-up trucks are frequently used too, especially in mountainous areas.

Conventions and unwritten rules

Using guaguas, especially the smaller vehicles, is an idiosyncratically Dominican experience. An instant bond of familiarity is formed, as passengers – mostly locals – are crammed four and five to a seat, Amway salespeople pester fellow passengers, Pentecostals proselytize to heathens and sometimes a bottle of rum is passed around. Most guaguas are operated by teams of two, the **driver** and the conductor, known as the **cobrador**, who sticks his head out of the sliding side door and drums up business. In this way, as well as getting them from the local **parada**, the usually small terminals from where guaguas depart, you can catch them by standing at the side of the road and waving your arms as they approach. Sometimes the **destination** will be emblazoned on the front, but if not you'll just have to ask the *cobrador* as the vehicle pulls up. For longer trips, you'll sometimes have to change guaguas at major towns. It's standard practice to shout for the driver to pull over whenever and wherever you want to get out (either "*Cuando puedas*" or "*Dejame*" usually does the trick) though you can also ask the *cobrador* to alert you when the bus arrives at your destination.

With one or two exceptions, such as the Expreso Bávaro which sells tickets an hour before departure, you pay your fare once on board and there is no ticket to speak of. Fares start at around RD$50 and rarely exceed RD$300 while the most expensive fares in the country currently hover around the RD$500 mark. Be aware, though, that attempted **rip-offs** of tourists are not unheard of. It's worth asking around to find out how much a given guagua ride costs before getting on board or, alternatively, sit towards the back of the vehicle so you can see how much other passengers are handing over as the *cobrador* works his way down the bus. Of course, you can ask the driver or *cobrador* for the price but you'll leave yourself open to the possibility that they will quote whatever they think they can get away with.

Schedule information

A basic source of online information on guagua routes and timetables, and the only one that attempts to cover the full country, is thebusschedule.com/EN/do. It's not actually a Dominican-specialist site and neither is it one hundred percent reliable but it's as good as there is for all the schedule information in one place.

By concho and motoconcho

Conchos are a cross between a bus and a taxi and operate mostly in the cities, most notably in Santo Domingo and Santiago. Often battered old cars, they usually work fixed routes and can be flagged down anywhere along the route – you'll need to ask a local where to go to flag a *concho* for any given destination. There are fixed fares for *conchos* – in Santo Domingo, for example, it's RD$25 and nowhere should it be more than that. You'll most likely have to put up with blaring music and some daredevil driving manoeuvres but most Dominicans depend on these vehicles, along with the guaguas, to get around the large cities and for anyone they are the cheapest form of urban transport.

Motoconchos, more prevalent in smaller places and particularly in the tourist resorts, are motorbikes used as taxis. They're faster than the *conchos* and fares are strictly by negotiation, though you should reckon on paying at least RD$50 and if you are recognizably foreign you'll have to work hard to get below RD$80. Be warned that they can often be dangerous and helmets are almost never worn and certainly never provided for passengers.

By taxi

Standard **taxis** are relatively expensive, especially in tourist areas and at airports and hotels, where prices are up to double the norm. Rates are often set, with meters rarely used, so you should **negotiate** the price beforehand – your best bet is to ring one of the firms listed in the chapters of this book, or use a taxi stand where the prices are posted. In whichever case, they should have an **official ID** in the windscreen and their union's logo somewhere on the car's exterior – unlicensed taxi drivers known as *pirates* often cruise the streets at night looking for business, but using these is not recommended at all. It is possible to hire a taxi by the day or half-day, which can work out cheaper (and certainly less hassle) than a rental car, depending on your negotiation skills.

Uber (uber.com) works as well as anywhere in Santo Domingo and Santiago, while the online-only airport transfer service run by Mozio (mozio.com) is an excellent way to get to and from any of the country's six international airports, often for a fraction of the cost of a standard taxi.

By car

Renting a car affords a freedom you may appreciate after a few days going from town to town on the guaguas, but with an infamous record on **road safety** you should only consider driving in the DR if you have experience of taking to the wheel in developing countries. Moreover, **never drive at night** – drink-driving is relatively common, headlights are never dipped, and many road users don't have working lights. Be wary, too, of stopping for people who look to have broken down, particularly on quiet roads – it may be a trap.

If you do take the plunge, you'll find that **car rental** is expensive in the DR, due to petrol prices, import duties and high accident rates, though you can cut your costs – and avoid a lot of hassle – by booking in advance with an **international operator** (Dollar and National are generally the best value) or reputable Dominican agency Nelly whose prices start around US$30 per day or US$125 per week. The international firms have branches at the airports and are far less likely to rip you off; if you don't have a credit card, though, you'll be stuck with the local companies, who accept passports in lieu of a security deposit, which is technically illegal.

If you intend to explore the beautiful coastal and mountain back roads that give access to the DR's finest scenery then a decent **4WD** is essential. These are available from most agencies, though some rental firms may try to entice you into choosing the cheaper Suzukis, which are the same price as standard cars, but they aren't really intended for rough mountain travel and, after the first bone-wrenching hour along a Dominican dirt road, you'll curse yourself for not spending more. You should also get **full collision insurance**; even with collision, though, you're usually contractually responsible for any damage up to RD$120,000. You should therefore take special care to note *all* dents, scratches and missing parts before signing off at the outset, especially with the local firms; nor should you sign the contract if a total price, including all hidden charges, taxes and fees, is not filled out. You can also check to see if you're insured by a **credit card company** (they sometimes provide it if you use it to pay for car rental) or your travel insurance cover, but check the details with a fine-tooth comb.

Americans can anticipate high **petrol** costs, while everyone else will find the prices about average at around RD$200 per gallon for regular gasoline. Premium costs a little extra, but seems to be worth it, especially if you need that tad more power in the mountains. Most petrol stations close around 8pm – and there are none whatsoever in the most remote regions – so keep a careful eye on your tank. If all else fails, look for one of the many roadside tables that offer individual bottles of petrol (usually in small/big beer bottles) for around RD$60/100.

Rental firms here charge exorbitant rates for **repairs**; if your car is dented you're far better off going to one of the local mechanics, who will charge at most RD$300 (as opposed to as much as RD$25,000). Because of the poor quality of many roads, **flat tyres** are a common occurrence; fortunately, every town has at least one *gomero*, independent tyre shops that work miracles for as little as RD$50.

Motorcycles can also be rented at many local firms, from around US$15–20 per day for a moped, though bigger machines (including dirt bikes) are also available, and necessary if you want to explore the rough back roads. When riding, stay as much to the edge of the road as possible (on bigger roads the emergency lane is for use by bikes) and sound your horn frequently. There is a motorcycle **helmet law** but it's barely observed and laughable local attempts to comply generally utilize baseball batting helmets or plastic American football gear intended for children. That doesn't mean that you should follow suit – insist that a proper helmet comes with your bike. Be warned that **motorbike thefts** are extremely common, especially in resort areas, so keep it locked when you're not riding it.

Road rules and dangers

Dominicans drive on the **right-hand side of the road**, usually at a breakneck pace. You'll have to keep a careful eye out along the highways, as large commercial buses and cargo trucks constantly veer into the opposite lane to pass slower vehicles, and other drivers often stay near the centre of the road to avoid the many motorbikes.

An array of **signals** using car horns and lights are employed by local motorists. Frequent honking is highly advised to stay safe; you should at least sound the horn while overtaking or – especially – passing parked cars. A driver about to pass you will often blink the headlights, while one coming towards you doing this is signalling that they're in your lane and you should slow down or get out of the way. One other important rule is that if you hesitate it means you've given way, even if you have the right of way.

You'll also find a bewildering variety of **obstacles** in your path, including turtle-paced ice-cream trucks, *motoconchos* with comical cargoes of piled chicken coops or construction equipment (which the driver holds down with one arm) and children running back and forth along the freeway. Potholes are common and you must be wary of vehicles suddenly swerving to avoid them, and of course be wary of hitting them yourself. Note that some towns have convoluted **one-way systems**, often not signposted as such – keep a close eye on which way the cars are parked.

As you approach towns, also watch out for the nasty **speed bumps** which are often unmarked and obscured under the shade of trees. Originally intended to prevent accidents, they are now sometimes used by local police to slow passing cars enough that **bribes** can be exacted from them, though this has become much less common in recent years due to government campaigns. In the fairly unlikely event that you get waved down, either pretend not to see them and carry on, or to speak no Spanish and keep repeating the word "tourist" and they'll usually let you go – otherwise RD$100 should see them off.

Finally, if you're in the vicinity of **coconut trees**, be careful where you park your car. All Dominican car rental agreements have a provision explicitly

ADDRESSES

Many **addresses** in the Dominican Republic indicate only the street and a number but sometimes the two streets that it is between are given too. For example, the address of a building at number 555 on Avenida Independencia between streets Socorro Sánchez and Benito Monción might be written Av. Independencia 555 e/ Socorro Sánchez y Benito Monción, e/ being an abbreviation of *entre* (meaning between). If a building is on a corner, then the abbreviation *esq.* (short for *esquina*) is used, though *y* is sometimes used instead. So the address of a building on the corner of Avenida Independencia and Socorro Sánchez could appear as Av. Independencia esq. Socorro Sánchez, or as Av. Independencia y Socorro Sánchez. Though you may sometimes see or hear a street referred to as, for example, Calle Socorro Sánchez, usually the *calle* is omitted and rarely used on street signs. Another abbreviation you may see in street names is Arz., short for *Arzobispo* (meaning Archbishop).

stating that insurance will not cover damage – usually shattered windshields or dented hoods – inflicted by a falling coconut.

Hitchhiking

Hitchhiking, or taking a "*vola*" is common in more remote areas, especially where no public transport exists. It is probably advisable only for experienced hitchers, and it's polite to offer a small recompense when you get dropped off, though usually they don't charge – try offering money three times, though. Often these vehicles will be beat-up trucks and you'll be sharing the back with as many agricultural workers as can be crammed in.

CAR RENTAL AGENCIES

Alamo alamo.com.
Avis avis.com, avis.co.uk.
Budget budget.com.
Dollar dollar.com.
Enterprise Rent-a-Car enterprise.com, enterprise.co.uk.
Hertz hertz.com.
National nationalcar.com.
Nelly nellyrac.com.
Thrifty thrifty.com.

Agents and operators in the DR

For the widest selections of excursions, trips to remote parts of the country or for specialist-interest tours, such as photography or canyoning, it's well worth contacting one of these local agents.

Colonial Tour & Travel 809 688 5285, colonialtours.com.do. One of the most established and professional tour operators in the country with branches in Santo Domingo, Punta Cana, La Romana, Las Terrenas and Boca Chica.

DS Voyages 809 472 6589, ds-voyages.com. Specialist in trips to Haiti from the DR, this Santo Domingo-based agent also arranges Spanish courses for visitors and tours to all the major tourist destinations.

Tours, Trips, Treks & Travel 809 867 8884, 4tdomrep.com. Ethically driven and run by Rochester, New York native Richard Weber, this excellent independent operator focuses on educational travel, adventure tours and bespoke travel programmes.

WICKED Travel 809 682 6307, dominicanexpert.com. Arranges stays at a yoga retreat, golf trips, mountain hikes, honeymoons, weddings and holidays customized to LGBT travellers. Also a good option for arranging group and corporate tours.

Accommodation

The Dominican Republic has become the most visited destination in the Caribbean thanks to its preponderance of all-inclusive hotels, which make package vacations here far cheaper than elsewhere. Plenty of other options, however, exist for independent travellers on all budgets.

There are luxury high-rise resorts along the capital's Malecón, independently operated beach hotels, rooms for rent in Dominican family homes and an assortment of bearable budget hotels – many with private bath, hot water and air conditioning – and a gradually growing range of cheap-as-chips hostels.

Away from the main tourist spots you can expect to pay around US$20–40/£16–32 for the night; in resort towns prices rise to US$40–100/£32–80. Reservations are essential for some of the all-inclusives at any time of year and if you want to stay in an independent hotel during the high season you will need to book in advance in the major resort towns, but should be able to wing it elsewhere.

Most hotels, of any kind, accept payment in both dollars and pesos but usually advertise their prices only in one currency or the other and, to be on the safe side, it's best to be ready to pay in whichever that is – the currency we quote for each hotel in this guide reflects each establishment's preference.

Independent hotels, hostels and pensiones

When travelling, most Dominicans stay at the spartan **budget hotels** that you'll find dotted throughout the country. If you do likewise you'll save a lot of money, but beware – you often get what you pay for. That means fairly nondescript, box-like rooms, best avoided except for sleep. Some of them have a shared bath and the majority have cold showers. Keep in mind also that when a budget hotel boasts "hot water" showers, this often means a large plastic nozzle on the showerhead that heats the water on the spot, making for a somewhat tepid temperature. Whatever you do, don't touch the nozzles when wet, or you'll risk a painful **electric shock**. Look to spend about

TOP 5 PLACES TO STAY ON A BUDGET

La Choza, Santo Domingo See p.74.
Island Life Backpackers Hostel, Santo Domingo See p.75.
Bávaro Hostel, Bávaro See p.115.
El Fogón, near Luperón See p.189.
Centro Jardín Verde de Río Limpio, Río Limpio See p.201.

ACCOMMODATION PRICES AND SEASONS

Throughout the guide, unless otherwise stated, the price listed is for the **cheapest double room in high season**. High season for most hotels is mid-December to April and July and August but some hotels have year-round rates. You'll usually get a significant discount off the prices listed for all-inclusives by booking with a travel agent as part of a package before you arrive. Make sure the price you are quoted includes the 23-percent hotel room tax. Though plenty of hotels do include breakfast in their prices it is not included as standard so always check.

RD$500–1000 (US$12–25) for these establishments, though some, especially in the cities, also offer rooms with air conditioning and television for around RD$200 (US$5) extra. It's easy to mistake the many roadside **cabañas turísticas** for budget traveller hotels; identifiable by their garish decor and the words "Cabañas Turísticas" emblazoned on the outside, these are in fact the type of hotel that charges by the hour and are mainly used by local couples.

In areas regularly frequented by foreigners, including some of the beach resorts, there is usually a good choice of independent **mid-range** (US$35–70) and **upmarket boutique** (US$80–150) **hotels**. The Zona Colonial in Santo Domingo has a particularly high concentration of decent independent establishments but you'll also find a good spread in Las Terrenas, Juan Dolio and Cabarete. At those independents aimed at business travellers you can often get better rates (up to thirty percent off) on weekends.

There are no official **HI (Hostelling International)** venues in the DR, but the expanding range of **independent hostels** is making budget travel a little easier. Another good way to cut expenses is to use the traditional **pensiones** that you'll still find in many towns, though they are increasingly being replaced by Airbnb and similar-style room rentals. These are rooms within a private Dominican home and so offer an excellent opportunity for contact with local people. Pensiones vary widely in quality, so you should have a good look at your room before deciding. If you want to shop around, don't feel guilty about seeing the room and then moving on; expect to pay RD$500–700.

All-inclusive hotels

The Dominican Republic is the archetypal, high-volume **all-inclusive** destination, where a single price covers your room, all meals and drinks and a variety of activities. If you go all-inclusive, you should do so through a **package** arranged by a travel agent in your home country, which will cost you substantially less than arriving at the reception desk and asking for a room.

All-inclusives – most owned by large foreign chains – can be a wonderful opportunity for a peaceful, affordable beach vacation in relative luxury, usually right on the country's prime beachfront. Despite a blanket no-tips policy, the staff are generally pleasant and accommodating.

A long-standing issue, though, is the omnipresent **buffet food**, which is often below par; at many resorts you'll have the option of going one or two nights a week to a better à la carte restaurant on site and a few hotels also reserve some spaces for room-only deals, which will allow you to spend your money at restaurants in town. Nevertheless, the idea of having unlimited access to a resort's facilities at no additional cost is undeniably attractive and it's possible to counteract the claustrophobia that often comes with several days spent in the grounds by taking an organized tour or a guagua ride into the beautiful countryside beyond.

Camping

There are several **campgrounds** in the southwest Dominican Republic and along the Pico Duarte trails, though camping is a fairly unfamiliar concept here. Outside of the Barahona region though, your best bet is to ask permission first – from village residents if you're on the beach, or from a farmer with a large property if you're in the mountains.

TOP 5 IDYLLICALLY LOCATED PLACES TO STAY

Villa Serena, Las Galeras See p.138.
Paraíso de Caño Hondo, Parque Nacional de los Haitises See p.134.
Altocerro, Constanza See p.230.
Hotel Casablanca, near Barahona See p.250.
Blue Moon Retreat, near Cabarete See p.182.

Food and drink

Dominicans call their cuisine comida criolla and it's a no-nonsense, delicious – if often rather greasy – blend of Spanish, African and Taino elements, with interesting regional variants across the island. Meat is omnipresent and outside of the major cities vegetarians will often have to make do with rice and beans. If you take all your meals at an all-inclusive hotel, you'll get little sense of how Dominicans eat and drink; the bland "international" buffet fare and watered-down daiquiris on offer at these resorts just can't compete.

Meals and cooking styles

Dishes usually include rice and beans – referred to locally as *la bandera dominicana* (the Dominican flag) – using either *habichuelas* (red beans) or the tiny black peas known as *morros*. Most often the rice is supplemented with chicken, either fried, grilled or served *asopao* (in a rich, soupy sauce). Invariably, main courses come with *plátanos* (deep-fried green plantains), which locals often inundate with ketchup, and a small coleslaw salad.

Local **breakfasts** – traditionally starchy and huge, designed for people who are about to go and work the calories off – typically include *huevos revueltos* (scrambled eggs), sometimes *con jamón* (with bits of ham mixed in); *mangú*, mashed plantains mixed with oil and bits of fried onion; *queso frito*, a deep-fried cheese; *jugo de naranja* (orange juice; also called *jugo de china* in the southwest); and a strong cup of coffee, either *sólo* or *con leche*, but always with a healthy dose of sugar.

Dominican **lunches** are quite hearty and are generally consumed between noon and 2pm, but **dinner** is still the day's main meal and is almost always a family affair. Aside from the omnipresent chicken, popular main courses include *mondongo*, a tripe stew strictly for the strong of stomach; *mofongo*, a tasty blend of plantains, pork rinds and garlic; and *bistec encebollado*, grilled steak topped with onions and peppers. Special occasions, particularly in rural areas, call for either *chivo* (roast goat) with cassava, a crispy, flatbread inherited from the Tainos, made with ground yucca roots; or *sancocho*, considered the national delicacy, a hearty stew with five different kinds of meat, four types of tuber and a bewildering array of vegetables and spices.

For the best Dominican offerings, go for the **seafood**, which is traditionally prepared one of five ways: *criolla*, in a tasty, slightly spicy tomato sauce; *al ajillo*, doused in a rich garlic sauce; *al horno*, roasted with lemon; *al orégano*, in a tangy sauce with fresh oregano and heavy cream; and *al coco*, in a tomato, garlic and coconut milk blend especially prevalent on the Samaná Peninsula. You'll find that the tastiest local fish are the *mero* (grouper), *chillo* (red snapper) and *carite* (kingfish). Other popular seafoods include *langosta* (clawless lobster), *lambí* (conch), *camarones* (shrimp), *pulpo* (octopus) and *cangrejo* (crab).

Dominican **desserts** are good but extremely sweet; the best of the many types are the *dulces con coco*, made with molasses and coconut shavings. Also popular are *dulces de leche*, usually a bit bland, and *dulces de naranja*, composed of a molasses-orange marmalade that can send you into instant sugar shock. You'll also find a wide variety of cakes, custards and flans on offer, including a distinctive corn custard, *flan de maíz*. A healthier and usually tastier option is to explore the tremendous variety of **tropical fruits**. *Guineos* (bananas), *lechoza* (papaya) and *piña* (pineapple) are the most popular, but you won't regret trying the local *limoncillos*, tiny, delicious lime-like fruits sold in bunches, and *chinola*, Dominican passion fruit. The DR is especially known, though, for its out-of-this-world **mangos**; less famous, but simply delicious, are the *fresas* (strawberries) that are widely cultivated in the Constanza region and grow wild in the Sierra Bahoruco.

Where to eat

Eating out can be extremely cheap in the Dominican Republic, provided you stick to the modest-looking local establishments, many of which serve very satisfying food. In the more formal dining rooms, prices are, of course, higher but are usually still a bargain by European and North American standards. Either way, with the exception of the *cafeterías*, you'll be charged an eighteen percent **sales tax** on your meal (shown on your bill as ITBIS) and a ten percent "service" charge (shown as LEY). Bear in mind that the service charge is a legal obligation on both your and the restaurant's

TOP 5 PLACES TO EAT COMIDA CRIOLLA

Mesón D' Bari, Santo Domingo See p.77.
Adrian Tropical, Santo Domingo See p.77.
L' Hacienda, **Samaná** See p.132.
Eskina, Puerto Plata See p.166.
Comedor Luisa, Constanza See p.231.